

THE PROPHET MUHAMMAD

(peace be upon him and his family)

B. ABOUT 570 CE, MAKKAH · D. 11 AH, MEDINA

- **Where and when.** He was born in Makkah, a trading city in a dry valley with no river and no farmland, which lived on the caravans passing through it and on the pilgrims who came to the Kaaba.
 - **Who was ruling.** Nobody. Makkah had no king. It was run by an assembly of the heads of its clans, which is why an argument over one stone could stop the whole city for four days — there was no one with the authority to end it.
 - **Revelation.** Twenty-three years, from about the age of forty until his death. About thirteen of those in Makkah and ten in Medina.
 - **What he left.** The Qur'an, complete. The community at Medina, which had been a set of quarrelling tribes and left an agreement in writing between them. And a road: the Hijra, from Makkah to Quba to Medina, still walked.
 - **Khadija.** She ran a trading business of her own and sent caravans north under her own name. She employed him before she married him. When the early community had nothing, it was her money that carried it, and she spent it down to nothing doing so. *Traditionally, she was the first person to believe him.*
 - **Elsewhere in the world.** In the same years the Kaaba was being rebuilt, work was going on in China on the Grand Canal, linking the great rivers so grain could move north. In Britain nobody was building in stone at all.
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He died in Medina in 11 AH, in the house of Aisha, and was buried where he died.

Communities observe this differently. Ask your family which we follow — his birth is kept on the 12th or the 17th of Rabi al-Awwal, and his death on 28 Safar or 12 Rabi al-Awwal.

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